SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The facts the kids check (shoe size, where you were, what you wore, how you feel about squishies) live on your **Suspect Statement form**, not in this video. The box at the top of your script gives you the four answers to write on the form, the one or two things the video has to agree with, and the lines to keep word for word. Everything else is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. Wear whatever you like. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached are your script and a one-page Suspect Statement form. The top of the script gives you four answers to copy onto the form so the kids' clues line up; the rest of the form is yours, and true is funnier. The video is a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video and the filled-in form by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

RECRUITER ONLY · DO NOT POST

Statement answer key

Every suspect fills out the same one-page Suspect Statement. Four answers are scripted because the clues test them (Q1 where at 2:15, Q3 shoe size, Q4 what they wore, Q5 squishies); each person's script box lists theirs. The rest of the form is theirs to answer however they like. Collect the forms with the videos by [Oct 23]. Four go on the suspect board; the Chief's stays in the Detective's folder until deliberation (2:28).

Suspect	Q1 · At 2:15	Q3 · Shoe	Q4 · Wore	Q5 · Squishies	Suggested Q7 / Q8
The Principal	In a meeting. A meeting about the next meeting.	9	An orange sweater. School spirit.	Tick LOVE THEM. Explain: “I own ONE. It’s a cat. It’s for stress.”	No. Absolutely not. No. / I did not say squishies.
The Reading Specialist	The reading room. Where I always am.	9	Orange. It’s a school color. Half the building wears orange.	Tick DON’T GET THEM. Explain: “You squeeze it. It goes back. That’s it.”	No. If I wanted to steal something, I’d steal a good chapter book. / I just don’t understand the obsession these days.
The Librarian	Shelving. Alone. In the back. 2:00 to 2:30, every day.	7	My orange cardigan.	Tick LOVE THEM. Explain: “One on every cart. Shelving is stressful.”	No. If I had, they would be alphabetized by now. / Whoever took them… check their feet.
The Custodian	Write DECLINED TO COMMENT across the form yourself, then add "From Bureau records: shoe size 9, in the building at 2:15, blue uniform, loves squishies (seen squeezing one in the boiler room)."				Nothing. Act shifty on Oct 30.
The Chief (Mrs. Driscoll)	In my classroom. Teaching. I live here, basically.	9	An orange sweater. It’s festive.	Write “Don’t be ridiculous,” cross it out with ONE line so it can still be read, then tick LOVE THEM and write “Fine. Love them.”	The Chief is never a suspect. / I would like it noted that I am not a suspect.

Form question	Clue that tests it	Who it clears
Q3 shoe size	Clue 1 · Evidence Lab: footprint 26 cm = size 9	The Librarian (7)
Q1 where at 2:15	Clue 2 · Ghostbuster Lab: "seen in hall at 2:15"	The Principal (in a meeting)
Q4 what they wore	Clue 3 · Cipher Room: "snagged my orange sweater"	The Custodian (blue)
Q5 squishies	Clue 4 · Mummy Witness: the thief loves squishies	The Reading Specialist (doesn't get them)

The deliberation script (2:28)

A squad says "everyone's crossed off." The Detective, for the room: "Then your list is too short. Size 9. In the building at 2:15. Orange sweater. Loves squishies. Who else was in this building yesterday?" *(Someone says the Chief. The Chief: "I am NOT a suspect.")*

"Chief, you filled out a statement form like everyone else. For completeness. I have it right here." *(Pin it beside the other four. Read it aloud, including the crossed-out "Don't be ridiculous.")* "Detectives, check it against your clues. Then write your warrants."

VIDEO 1 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 1

VIDEO 1 — THE PRINCIPAL

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · The only interview with real information, and it arrives by accident. Deadpan. Hold the beats.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 1 · THE PRINCIPAL · 9:12 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- On your Suspect Statement form, write these four exactly (the kids check them against evidence): Q1 at 2:15: "In a meeting. A meeting about the next meeting." Q3 shoe size: 9. Q4 wearing: "An orange sweater. School spirit." Q5 squishies: tick LOVE THEM, "I own ONE. It's a cat. It's for stress." Answer everything else however you like; true is funnier. Hand the form in with your video.
- On camera only two things have to agree with the form: you were "at a meeting" at [2:15], and you own exactly one squishy, [a cat]. Want a different squishy? Change it on the form too, and tell the room parent.
- Must match the real jar: "the big one, on the high shelf [by the window], with [three] strips of tape." Describe the actual jar in the actual spot.
- Free to change: [four minutes], the kind of meeting, [tie or collar], what the squishy is for. Add one true detail about yourself; it lands harder.
- Keep exactly: saying "squishies" by accident, then "candy," then trying to un-say it. That slip is the whole party.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Look just beside the camera. Check your watch.)

I have a meeting in [four minutes], so let's make this quick.

You want to know where I was yesterday at [2:15]. I was in a meeting. I'm always in a meeting. Yesterday it was a meeting about the next meeting.

And you want to know what I know about the missing candy. Let me be very clear about this. I have not heard ANYTHING, and I know NOTHING, about anyone stealing the squishies.

(beat)

I mean candy.

(beat)

...Did I say squishies? What was I thinking! Candy. The candy. I know nothing about the candy.

(pause. Straighten your [tie or collar].)

I did not say squishies. I may have said squishies. It's a very common word. People say it all the time. In meetings. I am the principal of this school. I say a lot of words every day. Statistically, some of them are going to be "squishies."

(too fast)

And for the record, I have never even seen that jar. The big one. On the high shelf [by the window]. With the [three] strips of tape on the lid and the label that says "do not open."

(realize what you just said)

...Which I can only describe because people have described it to me. In meetings.

(pause)

Do I own any squishies myself? I'm the principal.

(beat)

...One. It's [a cat]. It's on my desk. It's for stress. This is stressful. (look at watch) I'm late.

(Stand up and walk out of frame. Leave the phone recording for 3 more seconds, then say, from off camera, slightly muffled:)

Is it off? Did it get the squishy thing? ...Can we cut the squishy thing?

(Then stop recording.)

VIDEO 2 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 2

VIDEO 2 — THE READING SPECIALIST

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec · Zero information. Genuinely does not understand squishies and is a little offended to be asked.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 2 · THE READING SPECIALIST · 11:05 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- On your Suspect Statement form, write these four exactly (the kids check them against evidence): Q1 at 2:15: "The reading room. Where I always am." Q3 shoe size: 9. Q4 wearing: "Orange. It's a school color. Half the building wears orange." Q5 squishies: tick DON'T GET THEM, "You squeeze it. It goes back. That's it." Answer everything else however you like; true is funnier. Hand the form in with your video.
- On camera, two things have to agree with the form: you were in the reading room, in the building, at [2:15], and you genuinely don't get squishies. Nothing you wear matters, here or at the party.
- Linked to another clue: the [foam avocado] squishy. The mummy's witness statement and the Chief's confession both mention the avocado one. Change it only if the room parent changes those too.
- Free to change: [the reading room] (wherever you actually work), [sounding things out / blending things], [chapter book], [the good bookmarks]. Swap in your real reading life.
- Keep exactly: "I just don't understand the obsession these days." The kids will quote it.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. A book in your lap, one finger holding your place. Look just beside the camera. You are missing a [reading group] for this.)

I'm missing a [reading group] for this, so.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? The reading room. Where I always am. [Sounding things out. Blending things.] The cycle of life.

Did I go near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I go near every room. I pull kids out of every room. That's the job.

(long sigh)

Okay. Can I say something about these squishies? I don't see what these kids see in squishies anyway. You squeeze it. It goes back. You squeeze it again. It goes back again. That's it. That's the whole thing. No plot. No characters. I just don't understand the obsession these days.

(beat)

So no, I didn't take that jar. Why would I take a whole jar of something I don't understand? You want to steal something, steal a good [chapter book]. Those have endings.

(pause)

And before anyone asks: yes, I have a key to the book room. I have a key to every book room. Nobody's accusing me of stealing [the good bookmarks]. (look back up) Are you writing that down?

(beat)

Last thing. Whoever has those squishies: there's a whole class of kids out there who can finish a [chapter book] in a day but can't go an hour without squeezing a [foam avocado]. Think about that.

(stand up)

I'm going back to the reading room.

(Walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 3 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 3

VIDEO 3 — THE LIBRARIAN

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec, WHISPERED throughout · Zero information, whispered throughout. Accidentally sounds guilty three times.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 3 · THE LIBRARIAN · 12:30 PM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- On your Suspect Statement form, write these four exactly (the kids check them against evidence): Q1 at 2:15: "Shelving. Alone. In the back. 2:00 to 2:30, every day." Q3 shoe size: 7 (whatever your real size is; the footprint is a 9, and this is what clears you). Q4 wearing: "My orange cardigan." Q5 squishies: tick LOVE THEM, "One on every cart. Shelving is stressful." Answer everything else however you like; true is funnier. Hand the form in with your video.
- On camera, two things have to agree with the form: you were in the building at [2:15] (your [2:00 to 2:30] shelving window has to include it), and you love squishies. Don't say a shoe size on camera. Wear whatever you like.
- Free to change: [shelving] (any solo task you really do), [on every cart], why it's stressful, [alphabetized] (any librarian joke you like better).
- Keep exactly: "Whoever took them… check their feet." It points the kids at the footprint clue.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whisper the entire thing, as if you're still in the library. Look just beside the camera.)

(whispering) I know I don't have to whisper. It's a habit.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? [Shelving]. I [shelve] from [2:00 to 2:30] every day. Alone. In the back. With no witnesses.

(pause)

That sounded worse than I meant it to.

Did I see anyone near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I saw someone in the hallway. Moving quickly. Carrying something. Hugging it, actually. Like a puppy.

(beat. Close your eyes.)

…I also hug things. Books, mostly.

(pause)

Do I like squishies? I love squishies. I have a squishy [on every cart]. They're very good for stress. [Shelving] is stressful. People put books back in the wrong place on purpose.

(beat. Realize how all of that sounded.)

So, to summarize: I had motive, I had access, and I hug things.

(long pause)

I'd like to amend my earlier statements.

(beat)

No. I did not take the squishies. But if I had, they would be [alphabetized] by now.

(lean in toward the camera, whisper even quieter)

One more thing for the detectives. Whoever took them… check their feet.

(sit back)

I don't know why I said that. I just felt like a detective would say that.

(Stand, push the chair in silently, walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 4 · PLAYS AFTER THE ARREST WARRANTS ARE READ

VIDEO 4 — THE CONFESSION — THE CHIEF

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · Starts defensive, cracks fast, ends with the location of the loot.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 4 · THE CHIEF · 1:15 PM · (recorded under protest)

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- On your Suspect Statement form, write these four exactly, because you match every clue on purpose: Q1 at 2:15: "In my classroom. Teaching. I live here, basically." Q3 shoe size: 9. Q4 wearing: "An orange sweater. It's festive." Q5 squishies: write "Don't be ridiculous," cross it out with ONE line so it can still be read, then tick LOVE THEM and write "Fine. Love them." Suggested Q7: "The Chief is never a suspect." Your form stays in the Detective's folder until deliberation; it is the proof the kids pin up last.
- On camera you repeat those same four facts, and that is enough; you don't have to own anything orange. If you want a visual tell at the party, wear anything orange, even a scarf from the bin. If any of these should change, tell the room parent before anything is printed; the footprint, the ransom note, the posters, the forms, and the case file change together.
- Linked to other clues: "squeezed one and whispered 'so satisfying'" is Squad Nightshade's witness statement; [the avocado one] is in Squad Specter's statement and the Reading Specialist's video. Keep both.
- Must match the Principal: "[He] walked in on me" and "[he] said squishies in a MEETING once." Use the Principal's real pronoun; the slip in Video 1 only works if the Principal is the one who knew.
- Free to change: [twenty] (the real class size), [a math lesson] and [fractions] (whatever you were actually teaching), "I live here, basically."
- Keep exactly: "It IS satisfying, though," "a swamp that's learning fractions" (or your subject), and the last four lines. "A very special light" is the cue for the blacklight finale.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Arms crossed. Look just beside the camera. You are offended to be here.)

I want it on the record that I am not a suspect. I'm the Chief. The Chief is never a suspect. That's how it works.

(beat)

Yes, my shoes are a size [9]. Lots of people are a size [9].

Yes, I was in the building at [2:15]. I'm a teacher. I'm always in the building. I live here, basically.

(beat)

Yes, I own an orange sweater. ...It's festive.

(pause)

And yes, I heard what the witness said. That the thief squeezed one and whispered "so satisfying."

(very long pause. Quietly:)

It IS satisfying, though.

(beat. Uncross your arms. Exhale.)

Fine. FINE. It was me. I took the jar. And yes, it was squishies. It was always squishies. Do you know why I labeled it "candy"? Because if I had labeled it "squishies," that jar would have lasted eleven minutes. Do you know what it's like to teach [a math lesson] while [twenty] squishies get squeezed in rhythm? It sounds like a swamp. A swamp that's learning [fractions].

So I didn't steal it. I RELOCATED it. For safekeeping. From myself, mostly.

(wince)

And yes, the Principal knew. [He] walked in on me. Mid-relocation. Arms full. I gave [him] [the avocado one] to keep quiet. Clearly that didn't work. [He's] terrible at secrets. [He] said "squishies" in a MEETING once.

(lean in, almost proud)

Where are they now? Somewhere in that room. In plain sight. Hidden the only way a teacher knows how.

(beat)

You'd need a very special light to see them.

(look right into the lens for the first time)

Nice work, detectives. Now go find them.

(beat)

And if anyone squeezes one during math on Monday, I will do it again.

(Reach toward the camera and stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031

Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

Name _____ **Job at this school** _____

1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?

_____

_____

2. Who can confirm that?

_____

3. Shoe size (we will check) _____ **4. What were you wearing yesterday?** Color counts. _____

5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

7. Did you take the Jar?

_____

8. Anything else the detectives should know?

_____

_____

_____

Signature _____ **Date** _____

OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness